

Shakespeare's Richard II

A Student Study Guide

UNIVERSITY & A-LEVEL EDITION



CHAPTER 1 OF 5

Historical & Political Context

The world that made *Richard II* explosive — and dangerous to perform.

Richard II as historical precedent

John Milton, *The Tenure of Kings and Magistrates* (1649)

Our ancestors ... when oaths both at coronation and renewed in parliament would not serve, thought it no way illegal, to depose and put to death their tyrannous kings. Insomuch that the parliament drew up a charge against Richard the Second, and the commons requested to have judgment decreed against him, that the realm might not be endangered.

Bolingbroke:

Fetch hither Richard, that in common view
He may surrender. (4.1.156)

Events of Richard's reign were known and spoken about at the time.

Controversial monarch - successfully deposed of. All of the other monarchs who had lost power did so after war or over bloody hands.

Richard II: The Historical King (1367–1400)

Reign & Deposition

- Reigned 1377–1399; deposed by his cousin Henry Bolingbroke (Henry IV)
- Uniquely deposed through political process rather than war or bloodshed
- Parliament drew up formal charges against him

Parliamentary Judgment

"The commons requested to have judgment decreed against him, that the realm might not be endangered."

Richard's case set a constitutional precedent: that even a crowned king could be held accountable through formal legal process.



Queen Elizabeth and the Earl of Essex (1601)

Elizabeth to William Lambarde, keeper of the records in the Tower,
August 1601:

QE: 'I am Richard II, know you not that?

WL: 'Such a wicked imagination was ... attempted by a most unkind
gentleman, the most adorned creature that ever your majesty made.'

QE: 'He that will forget God will also forget his benefactors. This tragedy
was forty times played in open streets and houses.'

"I Am Richard II, Know You Not That?"

Queen Elizabeth I's chilling remark after the Essex Rebellion of 1601.

The Essex Rebellion

Essex's supporters paid for a special performance of the play the night before the uprising — performed "forty times in open streets and houses."

Political Explosiveness

Depicting a monarch's deposition on stage was a direct challenge to royal authority — the theatre became a site of political provocation.

Elizabeth's Self-Recognition

The Queen identified herself with Richard — a ruler whose legitimacy was being questioned by ambitious nobles. Art mirrored politics.

Richard as Historical Precedent

Richard II's story was weaponised by writers across the political and religious spectrum.

1

John Ponet (1556)

Protestant exile — used Richard's case to argue that subjects could lawfully resist tyrannical kings.

2

Robert Parsons (1584)

Catholic polemicist — used Richard to question the legitimacy of Protestant succession to the English throne.

3

John Hayward (1599)

Focused on Bolingbroke's political tactics and Richard's strategic failures — not moral lessons but realpolitik.

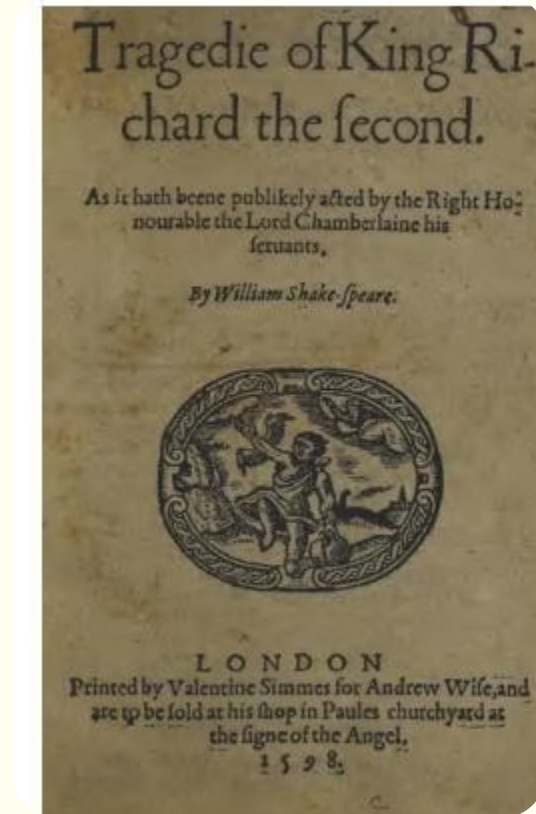
□ Both Ponet and Parsons wrote about obedience, succession, and the removal of bad monarchs — from opposite ends of the religious divide.

The Question of Succession

Elizabeth I was childless — the succession question was urgent and **dangerous to discuss openly**.

- Richard II dramatises the transfer of power without a clear legitimate heir
- Ideas of succession were "very much prevalent at the time the play was written"
- The deposition scene (Act 4, Scene 1) was **censored from early printed editions** — too politically sensitive to publish

The "missing scene" only appeared in print after Elizabeth's death — a telling act of editorial self-censorship.



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Key Characters & Relationships

A king who speaks in poetry; a usurper who speaks in law.

Richard II: King, Poet, Victim



The King

Believes in Divine Right absolutely: *"Not all the water in the rough rude sea / Can wash the balm off from an anointed king"* (3.2.54–56).



The Poet

Extraordinarily lyrical in defeat — his language grows richer as his power diminishes. Adversity becomes his muse.



The Victim

Compares himself to Christ betrayed by Judas figures: *"you Pilates / Have here delivered me to my sour cross"* (4.1.250–51).

Henry Bolingbroke: The Pragmatist



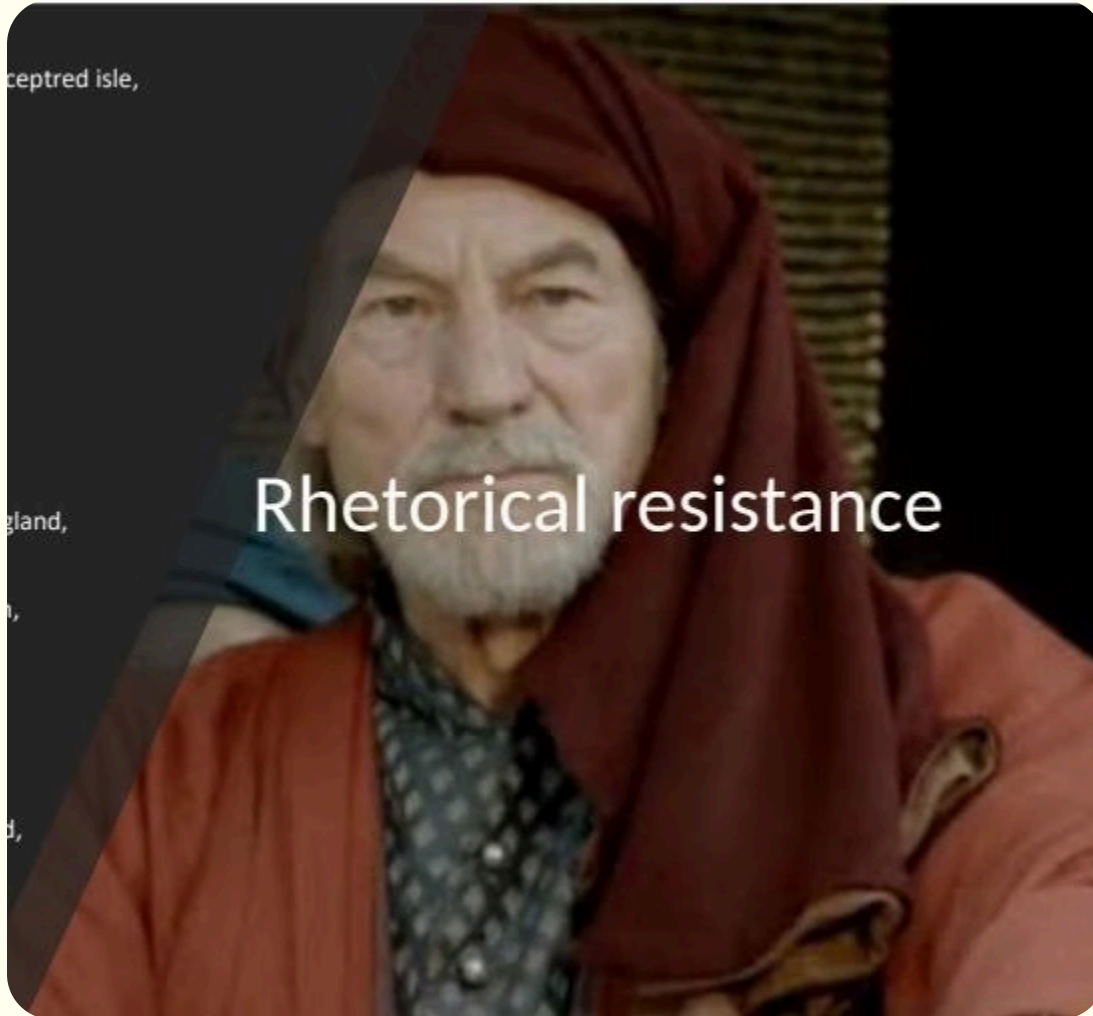
Language as Strategy

Where Richard speaks in poetry,
Bolingbroke speaks in plain, legalistic prose
— a deliberate and telling contrast.

- Returns from exile claiming only his inheritance (Gaunt's lands), not the crown — **but takes both**
- Publicly performs loyalty while advancing his power

"Henry Bolingbroke / On both his knees
doth kiss King Richard's hand / And
sends allegiance and true faith of heart"
(3.3.34–36)

The performance of deference is itself a political weapon.



John of Gaunt & the Duke of York

John of Gaunt — Passive Obedience

Refuses to avenge Gloucester's murder because Richard is "*God's substitute*" (1.2.37–38). Delivers the famous "**sceptred isle**" speech as a dying rebuke to a king squandering England's glory.

Duke of York — Torn Loyalty

Torn between loyalty to Richard and the claims of law and inheritance. Ultimately submits to Bolingbroke with resigned theodicy: "*Heaven hath a hand in these events*" (5.2.37).

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Rhetoric & Language

How the play's competing vocabularies enact its political conflict.

The Rhetoric of Divine Right

Richard's Theological Claim

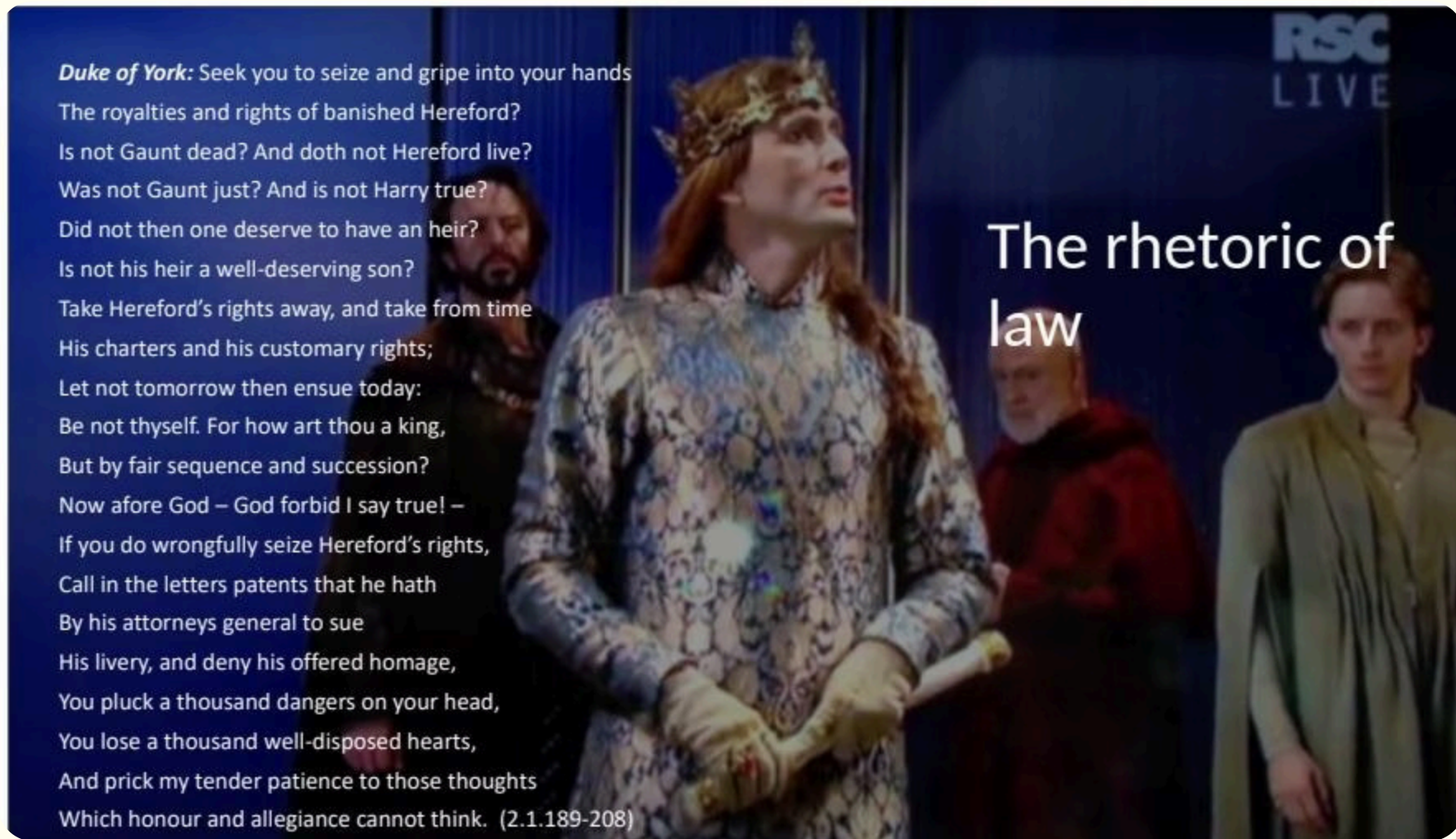
Richard insists his kingship is God-given and therefore inviolable — angels will fight for him.

"Disorder, horror, fear, and mutiny / Shall here inhabit, and this land be called / The field of Golgotha and dead men's skulls." — Bishop of Carlisle (4.1.144–45)

The Bishop voices the full theological stakes: deposing a king consecrated by God will transform England into a charnel house.

The Collapse of the Rhetoric

- Richard's divine-right language proves **politically impotent** against Bolingbroke's army
- York's eventual submission illustrates how the rhetoric crumbles under practical political pressure
- The gap between what Richard claims and what he commands is the play's central dramatic irony



Duke of York: Seek you to seize and gripe into your hands
The royalties and rights of banished Hereford?
Is not Gaunt dead? And doth not Hereford live?
Was not Gaunt just? And is not Harry true?
Did not then one deserve to have an heir?
Is not his heir a well-deserving son?
Take Hereford's rights away, and take from time
His charters and his customary rights;
Let not tomorrow then ensue today:
Be not thyself. For how art thou a king,
But by fair sequence and succession?
Now afore God – God forbid I say true! –
If you do wrongfully seize Hereford's rights,
Call in the letters patents that he hath
By his attorneys general to sue
His livery, and deny his offered homage,
You pluck a thousand dangers on your head,
You lose a thousand well-disposed hearts,
And prick my tender patience to those thoughts
Which honour and allegiance cannot think. (2.1.189-208)

The Rhetoric of Law & Property

York's challenge to Richard cuts to the constitutional heart of the play.

"Take Hereford's rights away, and take from time / His charters and his customary rights ... For how art thou a king, / But by fair sequence and succession?" (2.1.195–199)

Bolingbroke's Legal Framing

Frames his return as a lawful claim for inheritance — not rebellion. Legal language gives him moral cover.

The Central Collision

Absolutism vs. Rights & Property: The play stages these two rhetorics in direct conflict. If Richard can seize Bolingbroke's inheritance, Bolingbroke can seize Richard's crown — by the same logic.

The Sun Imagery



The King as Sun

Richard repeatedly associates himself with the sun — the supreme Renaissance symbol of monarchy and divine order.

- **Bolingbroke subverts it:** *"That sun that warms you here shall shine on me"* (1.3.147) — he claims the solar image even in exile
- **Richard's fall:** *"Thy sun sets weeping in the lowly west"* (2.4.21)
- **The Phaëton image:** Richard descends from castle walls *"like glist'ring Phaëton"* (3.3.181) — the mythological boy who flew too close to the sun and fell

The solar imagery tracks Richard's arc from divine certainty to tragic collapse.

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Close Reading: Key Speeches

The moments where Shakespeare's language reaches its greatest intensity.

"Let Us Sit Upon the Ground" (3.2.150–75)

Richard's meditation on the mortality of kings — one of the play's most celebrated and studied speeches.

"For within the hollow crown / That rounds the mortal temples of a king / Keeps Death his court, and there the antic sits, / Scoffing his state and grinning at his pomp, / Allowing him a breath, a little scene, / To monarchize, be feared, and kill with looks."

Reading the Speech

- *"Let us sit upon the ground / And tell sad stories of the death of kings"* — Richard abandons royal dignity for existential reflection
- The **"hollow crown"**: Death keeps court inside the crown itself, mocking the king's pomp with *"a little pin"* that *"bores through his castle wall"*
- The speech transforms failure into elegy — Richard's power to move us is greatest at his most powerless



The Mirror Scene (4.1.286–311)

The Demand

Richard demands a looking-glass at his deposition — a theatrical and psychologically charged act. *"No deeper wrinkles yet? Hath sorrow struck / So many blows upon this face of mine / And made no deeper wounds?"*

The Smashing

"A brittle glory shineth in this face. / As brittle as the glory is the face." Richard destroys the mirror — an act of theatrical self-destruction that embodies the collapse of his identity.

Bolingbroke's Reply

"The shadow of my sorrow" — his curt, pragmatic response refuses to engage with Richard's theatrics. The contrast between their modes of being could not be starker.

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Performance History

How actors and directors have reinvented Richard II across four centuries.



Staging Richard II: A History of Interpretation

Michael Redgrave — RSC, 1951

Stately, medieval pageantry. Established the "lyrical Richard" tradition that dominated the twentieth century.

1

Fiona Shaw — National Theatre, 1995

Dir. Deborah Warner. Gender-blind casting challenged fundamental assumptions about kingship, authority, and identity.

3

2

Richardson & Pasco — RSC, 1973

Dir. John Barton. The two leads **alternated the roles of Richard and Bolingbroke each night** — foregrounding their mirror-image relationship and the play's structural symmetry.

4

David Tennant — RSC, 2013

Dir. Gregory Doran. **Christ-like imagery** foregrounded — arms outstretched in the deposition scene, making the martyrdom subtext explicit.



Richard II on Stage: Key Questions for Study

Use these questions to guide your essays, seminars, and revision.

1 Casting & Identity

How does casting choice — gender, race, physicality — shape our reading of Richard's authority and vulnerability?

2 Tragic Hero or Self-Dramatiser?

Is Richard a tragic hero, a self-dramatising failure, or — crucially — both simultaneously?

3 Then & Now

How does the play's Elizabethan political context — succession anxiety, the Essex Rebellion — change how we read it today?

4 Language & Power

What does the play say about the relationship between language, power, and legitimacy? Who controls the word controls the realm.